Ode to Blue-Collar Workers

By Phil Levine, Bella Cardenas, Beverly Lafontaine and Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre

INTRODUCTION

Everyone has a story, but the sad fact of the matter is over the last several decades we as Americans have developed an unsettling tendency to make sweeping assessments about a person's worthiness as a human being based upon the kind of work they do. Cartpushers, cashiers, janitors, servers, bartenders - individuals working in these types of blue-collar, low-wage jobs simply don't make enough to support themselves, and if they have a family . . . the struggle to survive is even more overwhelming. They often take on 2 and even 3 jobs to stay one step ahead of the streets. Today I chose to tell the stories that most people never choose to hear.

Ode to the Blue-Collar Workers with the following poems: What Work Is by Philip Levine; Excuse me, Waitress by Bella Cardenas; Black Lung, Grim Future for Younger Miners by Beverly Lafontaine; and Cartpushers by Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre

What Work Is by Philip Levine

We stand in the rain in a long line
waiting at Ford Highland Park. For work.
You know what work is—if you're

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old enough to read this you know what
work is, although you may not do it.
Forget you. This is about waiting,
shifting from one foot to another.
Feeling the light rain falling like mist
into your hair, blurring your vision
until you think you see your own brother
ahead of you, maybe ten places.
You rub your glasses with your fingers,
and of course it's someone else's brother,
narrower across the shoulders than
yours but with the same sad slouch, the grin
that does not hide the stubbornness,
the sad refusal to give in to
rain, to the hours of wasted waiting,
to the knowledge that somewhere ahead
a man is waiting who will say, "No,
we're not hiring today," for any
reason he wants. You love your brother,
now suddenly you can hardly stand
the love flooding you for your brother,
who's not beside you or behind or

ahead because he's home trying to
sleep off a miserable night shift
at Cadillac so he can get up
before noon to study his German.
Works eight hours a night so he can sing
Wagner, the opera you hate most,
the worst music ever invented.
How long has it been since you told him
you loved him, held his wide shoulders,
opened your eyes wide and said those words,
and maybe kissed his cheek? You've never
done something so simple, so obvious,
not because you're too young or too dumb,
not because you're jealous or even mean
or incapable of crying in
the presence of another man, no,
just because you don't know what work is.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Philip Levine
ISBN: What Work Is (Section 1)
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): April 1992

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Excuse me, Waitress by Bella Cardenas

Slimy dishes and vigorous appetites
This is the life
Of a Waitress
Excuse me, miss

My potatoes are cold and
I can't seem to function without
Your absolute attention from those
Bright Brown Eyes

Oily skin from daylight sneers
Dirty and Discreet desire from clients
Dark rimmed eyes fill the face
Silent
Pauper-like stealth clicking up empty glasses
Five for five fingers, sweep
Swift, sly, unseen, insignificant
Just another Blue Collar
Reverse Prima Donna

Heavy trays and snapping fingers
Tinkling of silverware against what was
Porcelain, soft and beautiful

Now hard and marble

Beautiful beautiful

I pull down this ponytail and let

Luscious curls cascade over delicate shoulders

Take off the putrid uniform

And don a red dress of passion and fairytales

Take off the weary, trodden on

Face of disgrace

Replaced with beams of moonshine

Leave

Dreams wasted away on 5 dollar tips

And be a Queen you'll never know

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bella Cardenas
ISBN: Available On-Line Only
Publisher: PoetrySoup.com
Date (Month/Year): 2007

https://www.poetrysoup.com/poem/excuse_me_waitress_58512

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Black Lung, Grim Future for Younger Miners
by Beverly Lafontaine

44 and wasting, the coal miner says, "It's like

somebody's sitting on your chest all the time."

He covers his nose and mouth with a mask.

The ventilator resumes its vigil.

Outside, the sun barely warms the Kentucky air,

as clouds rush to fill the coming night sky.

The miner, his body a pot-bellied skeleton,

reminisces about a short-lived youth when

he felt like a man, his willingness to make the

mine yield the wealth of its deepest crevices

a source of pride, the price steep as his lungs

coalesced with the dusty air—black lung.

His father and grandfather were hollow men

at 60 years of age. Thanks to technology, his digs

were deeper, deadlier. "You'll die

to make other men rich," his father said,

Bitter this now, her meagre earnings,

five days a week steering a school bus,

are all that keep a tinny roof over their heads.

With little hope, he joins the vigil of stick men
outside the office of the senator who
doesn't come home to Kentucky any more.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Beverly Lafontaine
ISBN: Available On-Line Only
Publisher: PoetsReadingtheNews.com
Date (Month/Year): Aug, 26, 2019

http://www.poetsreadingthenews.com/2019/08/8977/

Cartpushers
by Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre

It's not rocket science. It's a ten-foot piece of rope with a hook at the end; we got three of 'em hanging in the equipment shed—one of 'em is thicker, but a little shorter; one of them looks thin as shoelaces but it's a half-foot longer. If you got first pick, take that one—looks flimsy, but trust me: you'll break before it does. Try to keep up.

See, these are the days before robots, and this is a city where people leave their empty apartments, leave their empty SUVs and finally, leave their empty shopping carts.

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Here. For us. You can hook seven together with that rope and push 'em back in. When it's busy, grab ten. When it's hell, stack thirty up and we'll push 'em in together.

Just be careful. Because these people: they'll look right through you when they back out of those spots. When they take that corner at thirty miles per hour. When they forget that they forgot to use a blinker and cuss you out for walking through a crosswalk.

See, to that guy, we're just background noise, uncredited extras in the eighty-year long made-for-TV romantic comedy that he calls life. We are neurons flickering stupidly, infantry stomping through the dreams he won't remember upon awakening.

So make sure you wear comfortable shoes. Boots in the winter. Sneakers in the summer. Add pads as you grow older. Grow older. Learn to control a convoy of carts without that rope; just balance, coordination and will. Learn to control the fist that lives in your neck.

When these people just leave their carts sitting in the middle of a parking space, swallow. When they look right

through you, swallow. When it's fifteen below and a straightjacket would be warmer than these flimsy company coats and you're working a double shift because you've heard rumors of layoffs, and the dapper manager saunters up and says how's it goin' chief? …swallow.

Understand: they will never understand this. The beauty of a parking lot at twilight, how the sky burns blue. The sweetness of every second when the big hand is on the eleven. The smile of the person who actually looks at you. We betray ourselves for seven dollars an hour. Our native language is white noise.

Cartpushers, cashiers, janitors, servers, bartenders: we are an army fighting a war we don't believe in, in a country whose name we can't pronounce, but we're fighting. And we're tired. But we're fighting.

And we're losing. But we're fighting.

You get two fifteens and a half hour for lunch. Those breaks aren't for your body, though. They're for your spirit. See, with an eight-hour shift broken up into quarters, that's just four two-hour shifts.

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After punching in, chatting with the MOD and putting your gloves on, you can glance at your watch and say Wow. I'm almost halfway to being halfway done with half of half of half my shift. It makes the time fly right by.

You'll be fine, kid. Just remember: smile. You're representing the company. Remember: say hello to people when they come in.

And remember: when they look right through you, you're still there.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kyle "Guante" Tran Myhre
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AWARD HISTORY

NE State Qualifier